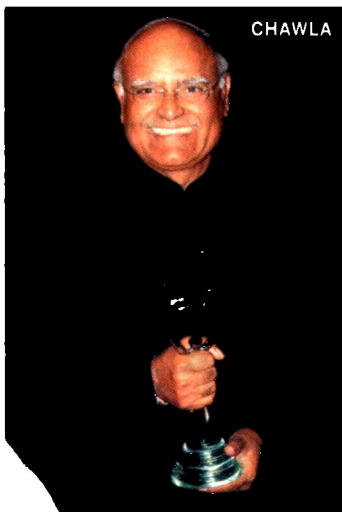


Aaj Tak was named the Best Hindi News Channel at the prestigious Indian Television Academy (ITA) awards 2009. Since its launch in December 2000, this was the ninth year in a row that Aaj Tak has won the award, making the title of Best Hindi News Channel its 20th accolade earned in the industry.

INDIA TODAY Editor Prabhu Chawla was named the winner of this year's ITA award for the Best News and Current Affairs Anchor for his programme *Seedhi Baat*. It was the second ITA award for Chawla and his popular *Seedhi Baat* talk show which features people in the news from politics, culture and sports. The show has also won several other awards in the

MUMBAI | Winning Streak



CHAWLA



KRISHNAN

television industry.

India Today Group Chairman and Managing Director Aroon Purie said that winning the ITA award for nine years in a row was a moment of pride for Aaj Tak and the TV Today team as well as a recognition

TV Today, who received the award on behalf of the channel at a glittering ceremony, said that the award was proof enough that Aaj Tak contained "the strength of a news brand—credibility and consistency".

HYDERABAD | Losing Fast

The maverick's grandiose plan may have stirred up a hornets' nest. Switching strategy from consensual politics and appealing to rival political parties, Telangana Rashtra Samithi (TRS) President K. Chandrasekhara Rao announced a fast-unto-death demanding the creation of a separate Telangana.

RAO IN HOSPITAL AFTER BREAKING HIS FAST



A PRABHAKAR RAO

But Rao's pre-emptive arrest hours before his hunger strike sparked stone-pelting, arson and self-immolation attempts by TRS supporters. Suspected TRS workers attacked offices of former Union minister Renuka Choudhury and former Congress MLA J. Venkat Rao (both Congress leaders) in Khammam, where Rao is being treated at a hospital.

When the TRS boss decided to discontinue his fast, his protesters were emotionally upset, wanting him to continue. For the TRS chief, pushing the cause for nine years, things could be no worse. Rao had failed to convince the Congress and the UPA—of which his party was a constituent—to accede to the demand for a separate Telangana state. After Rao lost further support when the Congress won fewer seats in the 2009 Lok Sabha elections than it did in 2004, he changed tack. Now, the UPA may pay attention, but Rao himself finds himself in real danger of losing even more face.

by Amarnath K. Menon

SHIMLA | Safety Calls

Anxious about bus drivers who use cellphones and cause accidents, the Himachal Pradesh Government has effected an amendment in the state's Motor Vehicle Act. Now, even carrying a mobile phone while driving a bus is an offence. Public bus drivers were not deterred when they were banned from using their mobiles last year. Now, bus drivers will have to leave their cell-phones at home. Nearly 8,000 people have been killed in the state's road accidents over the past decade.

by Arvind Chhabra